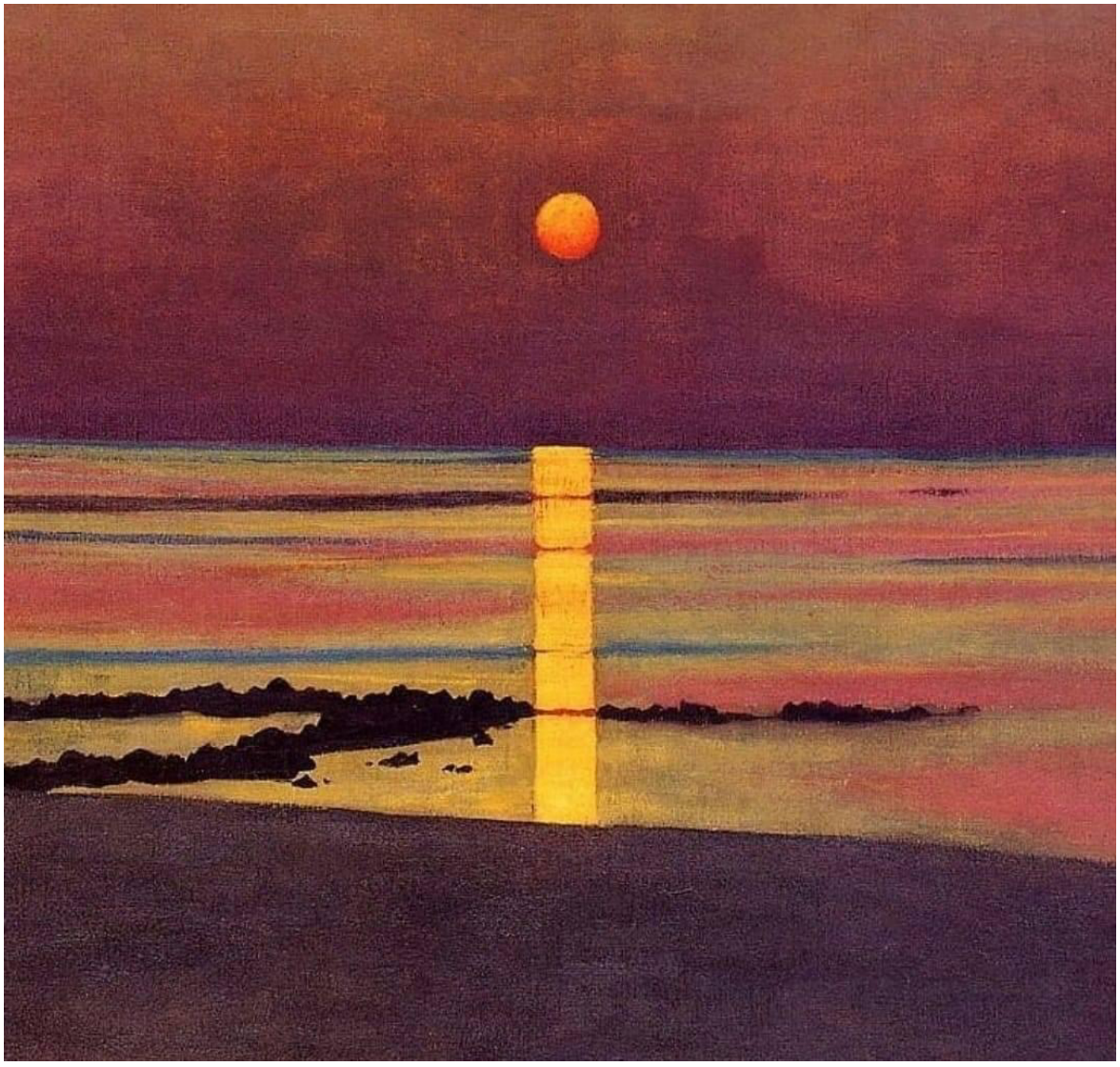
First Congregational Church
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 7
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Earth

18 October 2026



Coucher de soleil by Felix Vallotton, 1913

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~ Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Improvisation on LAUDA ANIMA and BUNESSAN
Paraphrases of two Preludes in C Major (C. Bull, after Bach)
Wer nur den lieben Gott läßt walten, BWV 647 (Johann Sebastian Bach)
Wachet auf, ruft uns die Stimme, BWV 645 (Johann Sebastian Bach)
Well-tempered Variations on a Bach Prelude in D minor (C. Bull, after Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome **Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

Words of Gathering **Sharon Duncan & Rev. Fregin**

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy One,
who is infinitely greater than words can express,
and yet is the Heart of our hearts,
and the Mind of our minds,
and whose love for us, and all creation,
exceeds our capacity to imagine.

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the Holy Oneness,
the web of life that holds all beings in intimate
embrace,
making it possible to distinguish, but never disconnect,
any part from the whole,
conferring kinship
in the kin-dom of God.

We open now to Sacred Mystery,
to the I Am-ness
that was and is and always shall be before our face;
before we were born, before the glorious becoming began.

In devotion, we open to you,
Great Thou of all creation.
In awe, we open to the Great Unity.
In humility, we open to the Great I Am. [adapt/bsanguin]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

Hymn of Gathering** ***Praise with Joy the World's Creator LAUDA ANIMA

Praise with joy the world's Creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise to Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upends religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride.
Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide,
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in community.
Calling people to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

***Prayer of Awareness** **Rev. Fregin**

Holy One, it is in the depths of life that we find you,
at the heart of this moment,
at the center of our soul,
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.
You are the Ground of all being,
the Well-Spring of all time,
Womb of the earth,
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait,
not for blessings from afar,
but for You,
the very Soil of our soul,
the early Freshness of morning,
the first Breath of Day.
Amen and Amen! [JPhilipNewell]

***Introit** I am the Earth TÄHT AND VALJAYAGA
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer** **Sharon Duncan**

Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kin-dom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.

For thine is the kin-dom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace** **Rev. Fregin**
In the center of the whirlwind lies an eye.
Still. Open. Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries, no storms, only peace.
As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must, may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home. [adapt/lvf]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition **Sharon Duncan**
From Exodus

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People **Rev. Fregin**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts
Holy One,
we acknowledge
that you are a Power, a Presence
within us
within all people.

You are a creative, energizing Presence,
bonding everything that exists
through patterns of attraction and co-operation,
in an endless movement
toward new possibilities,
creating an interrelational universe
that makes human life possible.

Conscious of your Divine presence
within and among us,
we can open ourselves to new possibilities.
We can expand our minds,
embrace change,
take risks,
and boldly discard what no longer gives meaning to life,
as we deepen our awareness and appreciation
of your Presence emerging in us.

We give you thanks for the wonderful gift
of conscious awareness.
We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with your energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and care for planet Earth.

To all that is - in this time and place,
and to all that can be through the power
of your Presence within all things,
we offer ourselves to bring your dream
for this world to fruition. Amen and Amen

[mmoorwood/adaptlvf]

Meditation Anthem Gather at the River STACEY V. GIBBS
Laude, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

Sermon ***Sacred Earth*** **Rev. Michael Lehman**

Invitation to Generosity **Sharon Duncan**

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory When Our Dreams Take Flight — MUSIC: DR. ROLLO DILWORTH
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor* — TEXT: PAUL LAURENCE DUNBAR

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer** — **Sharon Duncan**
Holy One, as your life flows through the rivers and streams of this earth,
remind us on this day, that your life also flows through us.
With these offerings we offer our thanks and praise
and ask that the Spirit of Life, Love, and Goodness
move freely in our words and actions.
Awaken in us, the possibility of new life, new vision,
and renewed meaning and purpose
as we follow in the steps of those
whose faith continues to flow
around us, among us, and within us.

Thanks be to you, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church — **Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin**

Words of Blessing — **Rev. Lehman**
May the deep blessings of earth be with us.
May the fathomless soundings of seas surge in souls.
May boundless stretches of the universe echo in our depths
to open us to wonder
to strengthen us for love
to humble us with gratitude
that we may find ourselves in one another
that we may lose ourselves in gladness
that we may give ourselves to peace.

Choral Response Way Over in Beulah Lan — STACEY V. GIBBS
Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

Hymn for the Journey** ***Come, See the Fullness — BUNESSAN
God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, mystr'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

Postlude **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Short Fugue in C Major (Ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Today's coffee hour is sponsored by Grace & Greg Williams to thank the Deacons for their contributions to our worship and community.

Inside The Music

"Today, as we reflect on the theme of **Sacred Earth**, we are invited to consider our relationship with the Earth, our responsibility to one another, and the holiness that surrounds us.

We begin with Täht and Valjayaga's *I Am the Earth*, a musical expression of our personal connection to the ground beneath our feet. When we recognize the Earth as an extension of ourselves, we are called to care for it with the same tenderness, respect, and love we would offer our own bodies. In embracing this shared responsibility, our individual acts of care become a collective expression of reverence for the sacred world we have been given.

Laude presents Stacey V. Gibbs' arrangement of *Gather at the River*, a song that evokes the biblical imagery of the River of Life. Rivers sustain the Earth, nourish its inhabitants, and remind us of the life-giving resources upon which our existence depends. As we gather at the river in song, we are invited to reflect on the ways these sacred waters sustain not only our physical lives but also our spiritual journeys through a world that is both beautiful and complex.

Rollo Dilworth's *When Our Dreams Take Flight*, inspired by Paul Laurence Dunbar's poem "Dreams," explores the fragile yet enduring nature of our hopes and ambitions. Through vivid images drawn from the natural world, including rosy clouds and withering flowers, Dunbar reflects on the vulnerability of dreams and the sorrow that can accompany their loss. Dilworth's warm, accessible Gospel harmonies offer a message of hope: when we come together in community, we can encourage one another, nurture our aspirations, and help one another's dreams take flight.

Finally, the Cathedral Choir offers an excerpt from Gibbs' *Beulah Land*, a powerful expression of the longing for a promised land of freedom, peace, and joy. For some, this land represents the heavenly home toward which we journey; for others, it inspires a vision of liberation and wholeness that we can begin to realize here on Earth. Through our commitment to justice, our care for creation, and our love

for one another, we participate in making this sacred ground a place where freedom and joy can flourish.

As we listen, may the music awaken us to the holiness of the Earth beneath our feet. Like Moses before the burning bush, may we pause in reverence, recognize the divine presence in the world around us, and remember that this sacred ground is both a gift to cherish and a responsibility to uphold." ~ *Brandon Harris*

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